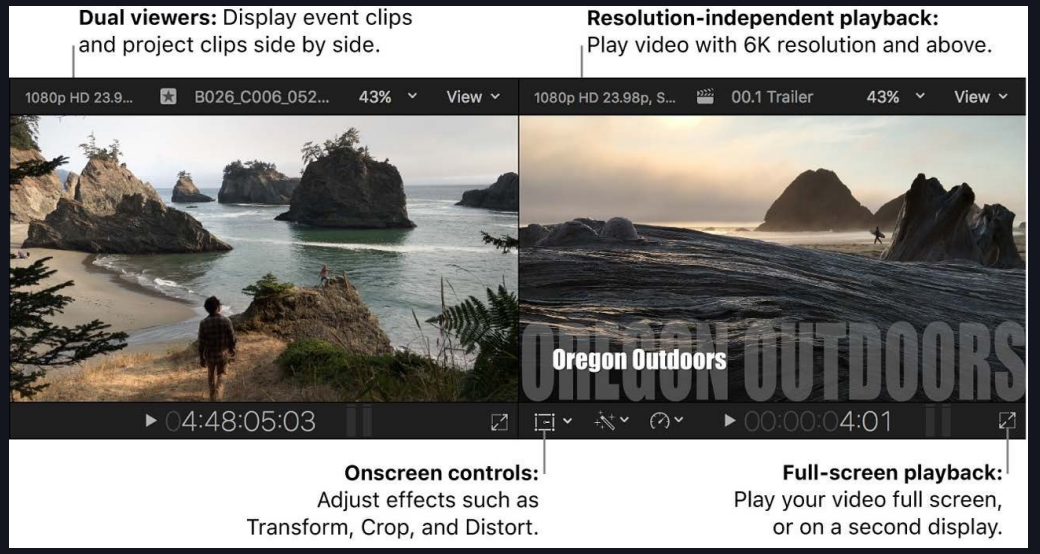
MY LEARNING PLAYBOOK · FCP 12.4

Final Cut Pro in 30 Days

Learn FCP, make Shorts and long videos fast, and upload to YouTube every day. Your go-to reference for the month.



Screenshots: Final Cut Pro User Guide for Mac (Apple)

How to use this book



1 · Learn

Watch one 10–20 minute video lesson on the day's topic.



2 · Do

Copy the steps in FCP straight away with your own footage.



3 · Check

Read only the manual pages listed on the day's page.



4 · Publish

Use the new skill in today's upload. Publishing is practice.

EVERY DAY PAGE HAS

A goal · the steps · a "Try it" task · today's upload · key shortcuts · manual pages · a screenshot · a My notes box. Type what you learned into My notes each day, and by Day 30 this book becomes your own Final Cut Pro manual.

Learn from video, look things up in the manual



Video lessons

Use to LEARN

- Shows real mouse and keyboard movement
- Easiest way to learn the timeline and trimming
- 10–20 minute lessons fit your daily plan



User Guide (manual)

Use to LOOK THINGS UP

- Most accurate and always up to date
- Read only the pages for today's topic
- Search it when you're stuck (Help menu)



Slides or presentations

Use only for SUMMARIES

- Can't show how an edit is done
- Fine for a shortcut cheat sheet
- This book is your summary and notes

Your 30 days at a glance

1 Days 1–7

Core editing

Learn the interface and the basic edit: import, cut, audio, captions, export.

UPLOAD

One simple vertical Short every day (15–60 sec)

2 Days 8–14

Speed and polish

Work faster with shortcuts and templates, and make your clips look and sound better.

UPLOAD

Shorts daily, plus your first long video (3–6 min) on Day 14

3 Days 15–21

Creative tools

Masks, keying, tracking, multicam, music sync and thumbnails.

UPLOAD

A Short every day, plus long videos on Days 18 and 21

4 Days 22–30

Real-time daily workflow

Batch your work, manage your library, repurpose content and read analytics.

UPLOAD

A Short daily, plus a long video every 2–3 days

Your free month: Apple Creator Studio

6

apps included: Final Cut Pro, Motion, Compressor, Pixelmator Pro, Logic Pro, MainStage

26.6

minimum macOS version for FCP 12.4 (p. 6)

M-chip

Apple silicon needed for Generate Captions (U.S. English only, p. 385)

MAKE THE MOST OF THE TRIAL

- Make thumbnails in Pixelmator Pro (Share > Send Frame to Pixelmator Pro, p. 828)
- Use the extra downloadable titles, transitions and generators (p. 18)
- Cancel or change it in Final Cut Pro > Manage Subscriptions. You keep access until the billing period ends (p. 18)
- Decide on Day 30 whether to continue

Day 0: set up before you start



Verify your channel

youtube.com/verify unlocks videos over 15 min and custom thumbnails.



Pick one format

For example “1 tip in 45 seconds”. A repeatable format makes daily uploads realistic.



Make folders

Footage · Music · Graphics · Exports. Keep the same structure every week.



Copyright-safe music

Download tracks from the YouTube Audio Library.



Shoot on your phone

4K or 1080p at 30 fps. Apple’s Final Cut Camera app works with FCP (p. 42).



Keep a clip stock

Have 5–10 spare clips ready so you never start from zero.

Where to learn

FREE

FCP User Guide

Help > Final Cut Pro Help, or support.apple.com/guide/final-cut-pro. Start with p. 7–15.

FREE

Built-in demo project

Practise on Apple's footage before your own (p. 19).

FREE · YOUTUBE

Ripple Training

Clear, structured FCP lessons and "what's new" videos.

FREE · YOUTUBE

Dylan Bates (The Final Cut Bro)

Practical tips, workflows and shortcuts.

FREE · YOUTUBE

Primal Video

Beginner FCP guides plus YouTube growth advice.

PAID · OPTIONAL

Apple Pro Training Series

Official Peachpit book with practice media. LinkedIn Learning is another option.

WEEK 1 · DAYS 1–7

Core editing

Learn the interface and the basic edit: import, cut, audio, captions, export.

Day 1 Meet the Final Cut Pro interface
Day 2 Import, organise and create a vertical project
Day 3 Add clips to the magnetic timeline
Day 4 Cut and trim like a pro
Day 5 Clean, balanced audio
Day 6 Titles and automatic captions
Day 7 Export and upload to YouTube

UPLOAD TARGET

One simple vertical Short every day (15–60 sec)

END-OF-WEEK CHECK

You can make a 30-second captioned Short in under 45 minutes

DAY 1

Meet the Final Cut Pro interface

Know where everything lives before you edit anything.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Open FCP and create a library (File > New > Library)
2. Find the four main areas: browser, viewer, timeline, inspector
3. Open the demo project (p. 19) and play it with the Spacebar
4. Show or hide the inspector with Cmd+4 and the Libraries sidebar with Cmd+1



From the FCP User Guide, p. 14

TRY IT

Skim the demo footage by moving the pointer over clips, then play the timeline.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

▶ Final Cut Pro Tutorial: Step-By-Step For Beginners (2025) – Primal Video
+ Final Cut Pro Tutorial for Beginners – COMPLETE Guide

PUBLISH TODAY

Short: a talking-head intro to your channel

KEY SHORTCUTS

Space · Cmd+4 · Cmd+1

MANUAL PAGES

p. 7–19

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

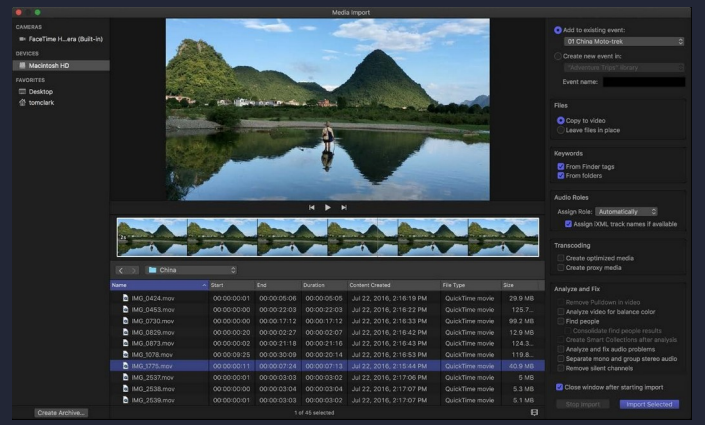
DAY 2

Import, organise and create a vertical project

Get footage in, keep it tidy, and set up a 9:16 timeline.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Import with Cmd+I, or drag files from Finder into an event
2. Mark good takes as Favourite (F) and add keywords
3. New project (Cmd+N) > Use Custom Settings
4. Set the resolution to Vertical 1080×1920 at 30 fps for Shorts



From the FCP User Guide, p. 21

TRY IT

Import 10 clips, favourite your 3 best, and create a project called “Short-Template”.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

▶ Vertical Videos in Final Cut Pro: Reels, TikTok & Shorts
+ FCP Masterclass: Import, Organize, and Edit Like a Pro

PUBLISH TODAY

Short

KEY SHORTCUTS

Cmd+I · Cmd+N · F

MANUAL PAGES

p. 21–38, 89, 120–127

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

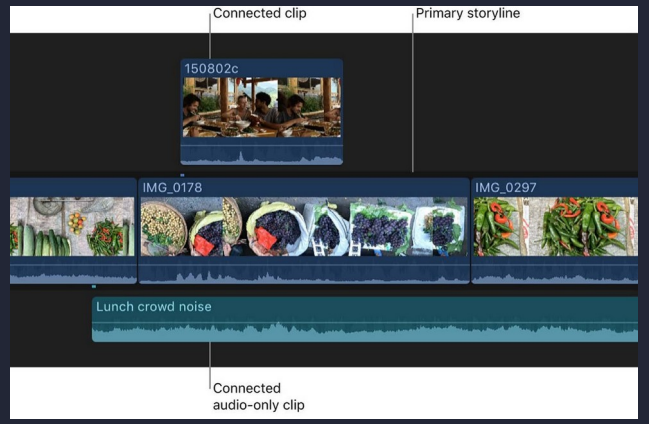
DAY 3

Add clips to the magnetic timeline

Build a rough cut with the four basic edit types.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. E appends the selection to the end of the timeline
2. W inserts at the playhead; D overwrites
3. Q connects B-roll above the main storyline
4. Use I and O to choose only part of a clip before you add it



From the FCP User Guide, p. 137

TRY IT

Make a 30-second rough cut using only the keyboard: I, O, E, W, Q.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Complete Guide To Final Cut Pro's Magnetic Timeline
+ Beginner Tutorial: Edits – Connect, Insert & Append

PUBLISH TODAY

Short

KEY SHORTCUTS

E · W · Q · D · I · O

MANUAL PAGES

p. 70, 136–155

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

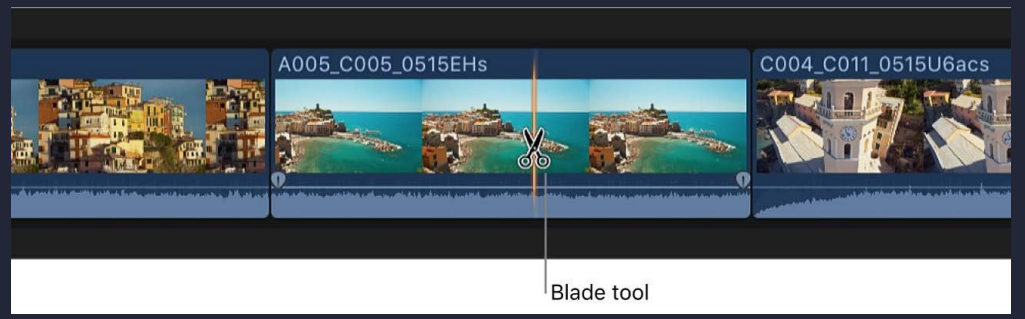
DAY 4

Cut and trim like a pro

Tighten pacing with jump cuts and precise trims.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Cmd+B cuts at the playhead; B switches to the Blade tool
2. Opt+[and Opt+] trim a clip's start or end to the playhead
3. Use the Trim tool (T) for roll, slip and slide edits
4. Play with J, K, L; tap L twice for double speed



From the FCP User Guide, p. 169

TRY IT

Remove every pause and "um" from a 1-minute talking clip.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

How to do Ripple, Roll, Slip and Slide Edits in Final Cut Pro
+ How To Trim in FCP with Ripple, Roll, Slip and Slide

PUBLISH TODAY

Short with tight jump cuts

KEY SHORTCUTS

Cmd+B · Opt+[· Opt+] · T

MANUAL PAGES

p. 162–187

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

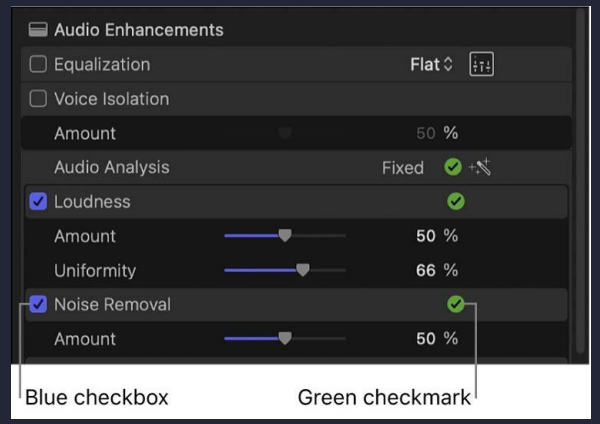
DAY 5

Clean, balanced audio

Good sound matters more than good picture.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Drag the volume line on a clip to set its level
2. Drag the fade handles at the edges for smooth fades
3. Inspector > Audio > Voice Isolation removes background noise
4. Opt+Cmd+A runs Enhance Audio; keep music around −20 dB under voice



From the FCP User Guide, p. 277

TRY IT

Add music under your voice and fade it in and out.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

How to CLEAN UP Audio in Final Cut (Voice Isolation)

+ How to Mix Voice and Music in Final Cut Pro

PUBLISH TODAY

Short with music under the voice

KEY SHORTCUTS

Opt+Cmd+A · Ctrl+S

MANUAL PAGES

p. 220–251, 276–278

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

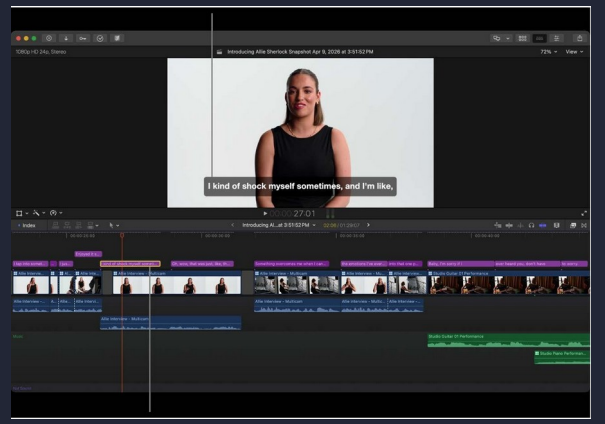
DAY 6

Titles and automatic captions

Most Shorts are watched without sound, so add captions.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Ctrl+T adds a basic title; Ctrl+Shift+T a lower third
2. Select speech clips, then press Shift+Cmd+S (Generate Captions > Subtitles)
3. Edit the text in the inspector and fix any wrong words
4. Captions need an Apple silicon Mac and U.S. English (p. 385)



From the FCP User Guide, p. 385

TRY IT

Generate captions for a Short and restyle them big and bold.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

▶ Final Cut Pro • Complete Guide To Transcribe To Captions
+ How To Add The Default Title Or Lower Third in FCP

PUBLISH TODAY

Short with captions

KEY SHORTCUTS

Ctrl+T · Shift+Cmd+S

MANUAL PAGES

p. 287, 355, 385–387

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

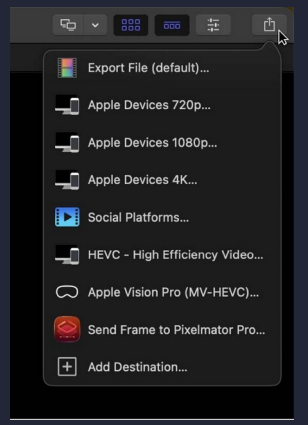
DAY 7

Export and upload to YouTube

Finish the loop: from timeline to YouTube.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Click the Share button > Social Platforms (p. 894)
2. For Shorts, turn on Burn in captions
3. Choose Multi-pass for quality, or Single-pass for speed
4. Upload the file in YouTube Studio and add #Shorts



From the FCP User Guide, p. 806

TRY IT

Export and upload today's Short, then review the whole week.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

BEST Export Settings for YouTube for 2026 (Final Cut Pro)
+ Export in FCP for YouTube, Instagram, TikTok (Beginner)

PUBLISH TODAY

Short, plus a review of your week

KEY SHORTCUTS

Cmd+E (default share)

MANUAL PAGES

p. 806–810, 894

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today...

WEEK 2 · DAYS 8–14

Speed and polish

Work faster with shortcuts and templates, and make your clips look and sound better.

Day 8 Keyboard shortcuts and the Command Editor
Day 9 Transitions and effects
Day 10 Speed ramps, holds and freeze frames
Day 11 Transform, crop and Smart Conform
Day 12 Colour basics: Enhance Light and Color
Day 13 Compound clips and your Short template
Day 14 Roles, markers and YouTube chapters

UPLOAD TARGET

Shorts daily, plus your first long video (3–6 min) on Day 14

END-OF-WEEK CHECK

A Short takes under 30 minutes using your template

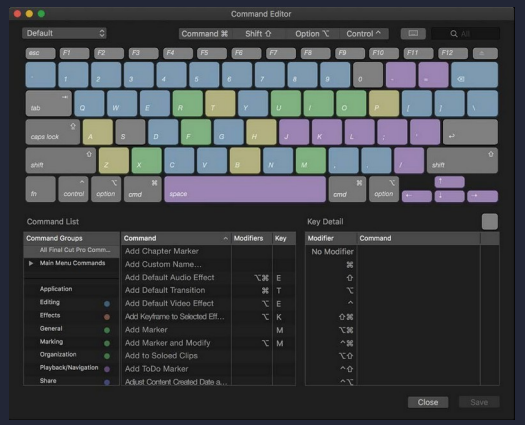
DAY 8

Keyboard shortcuts and the Command Editor

Editing speed comes from your hands, not the mouse.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Open the Command Editor with Opt+Cmd+K
2. Click a key to see what it does; search for any command
3. Learn the tools: A select, B blade, T trim, P position, R range
4. Shift+Z fits the timeline; Cmd+ + and Cmd+ – zoom



From the FCP User Guide, p. 924

TRY IT

Edit today's Short without touching a menu.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

▶ 100 Shortcuts every FCP Editor MUST KNOW
+ 10 Final Cut Shortcuts That Will Double Your Editing Speed

PUBLISH TODAY

Short

KEY SHORTCUTS

Opt+Cmd+K · Shift+Z · A B T P R

MANUAL PAGES

p. 897–928

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

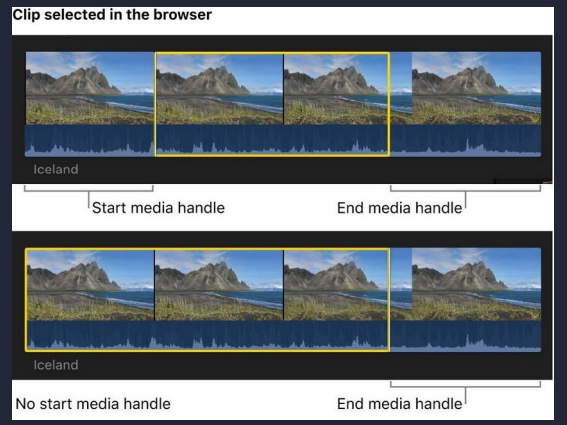
DAY 9

Transitions and effects

Use effects on purpose, not everywhere.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Cmd+T adds the default Cross Dissolve
2. Ctrl+Cmd+5 opens the Transitions browser; Cmd+5 opens Effects
3. Drag an effect onto a clip, then adjust it in the inspector
4. Rule: one transition style per video, used rarely



From the FCP User Guide, p. 390

TRY IT

Try 5 transitions, then keep only the one that fits your style.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

How to Add Transitions in Final Cut Pro

+ Final Cut Pro 11 Creative Effects and Mask Transitions

PUBLISH TODAY

Short

KEY SHORTCUTS

Cmd+T · Cmd+5 · Ctrl+Cmd+5

MANUAL PAGES

p. 388–400, 418

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

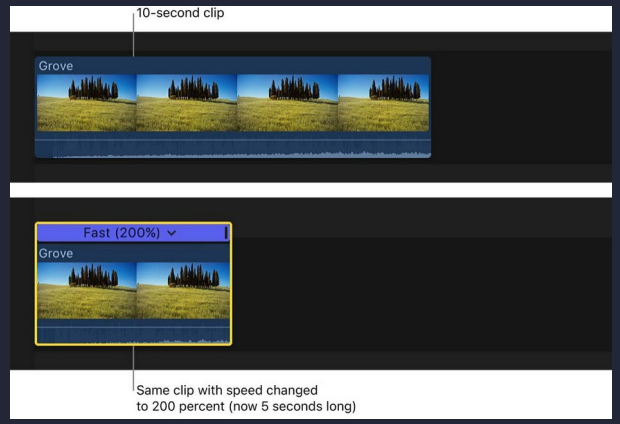
DAY 10

Speed ramps, holds and freeze frames

Speed changes add energy to Shorts.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Cmd+R shows the retime editor above a clip
2. Choose Slow, Fast or Custom from the retime menu
3. Shift+H adds a 2-second hold; Opt+F makes a freeze frame
4. Shift+N returns a range to normal (100%) speed



From the FCP User Guide, p. 559

TRY IT

Make a speed ramp: normal → fast → slow-motion on the key moment.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Retiming in Final Cut Pro (every option in the menu)
+ How to Speed Ramp in Final Cut Pro

PUBLISH TODAY

Short with a speed ramp

KEY SHORTCUTS

Cmd+R · Shift+H · Opt+F · Shift+N

MANUAL PAGES

p. 151, 558–574

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

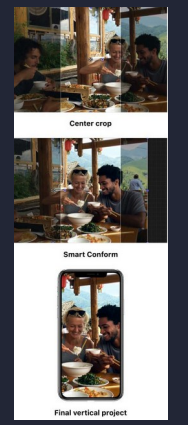
DAY
11

Transform, crop and Smart Conform

Reframe horizontal footage for vertical video.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Use Transform in the viewer to move, scale and rotate
2. Crop or use Ken Burns for slow zoom movement
3. Select horizontal clips in a vertical project > Modify > Smart Conform
4. Adjust Transform > Position if a face is still off-centre



From the FCP User Guide, p. 405

TRY IT

Turn a horizontal clip into a vertical Short with Smart Conform.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Create Vertical Videos FASTER with Smart Conform
+ FCP for Social Media: Smart Conforming, Titles + more

PUBLISH TODAY

Short made from horizontal footage

KEY SHORTCUTS

Shift+T (transform)

MANUAL PAGES

p. 401–405

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today...

DAY 12

Colour basics: Enhance Light and Color

Make every clip look clean and consistent.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Ctrl+Opt+Cmd+O applies Enhance Light and Color
2. Opt+Cmd+B turns Balance Color on or off
3. Opt+Cmd+M matches colour between two clips
4. Cmd+6 opens the Color inspector for fine tuning



From the FCP User Guide, p. 708

TRY IT

Fix one dark clip and one too-blue clip, then match them.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

▶ Final Cut Pro 11 – Enhance Light and Color Tutorial
+ Color Correction & Grading in FCP in Under 60 Minutes

PUBLISH TODAY

Short

KEY SHORTCUTS

Ctrl+Opt+Cmd+O · Opt+Cmd+M · Cmd+6

MANUAL PAGES

p. 708–715, 746–749

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

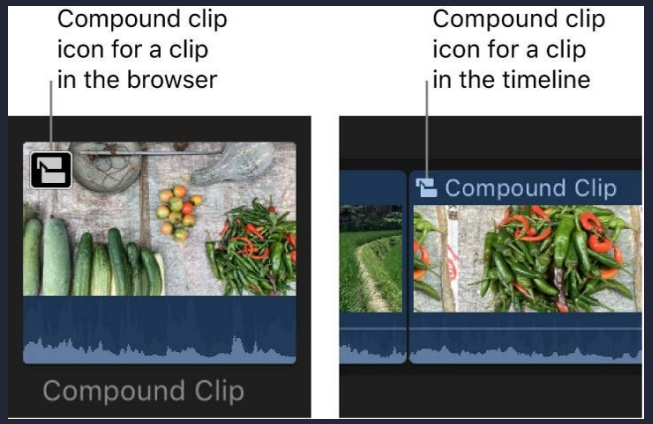
DAY 13

Compound clips and your Short template

Build once and reuse every day.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Select clips and press Opt+G to make a compound clip
2. Build a template: hook title, caption style, music, end card
3. Duplicate the project for each new Short (Cmd+D in the browser)
4. Save a favourite title style so it's always one click away



From the FCP User Guide, p. 505

TRY IT

Build your "Short-Template" project and make today's Short from it.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

How to Create & Use Compound Clips in Final Cut Pro
+ Final Cut Pro in Under 5 Minutes: Building Title Templates

PUBLISH TODAY

Short made from your template

KEY SHORTCUTS

Opt+G · Cmd+D

MANUAL PAGES

p. 504–512

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

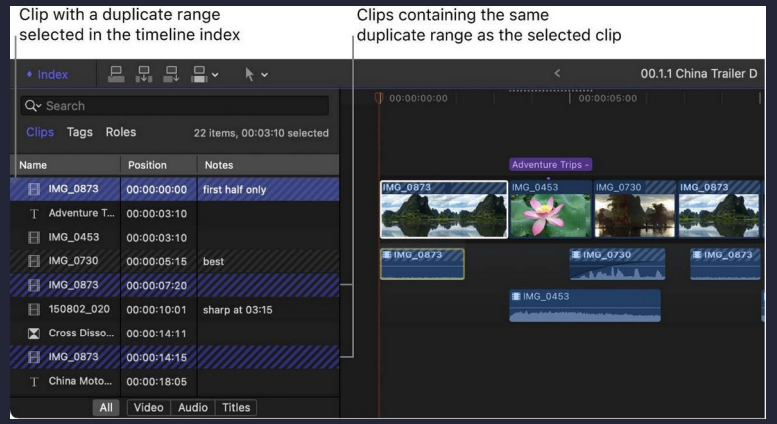
DAY 14

Roles, markers and YouTube chapters

Organise longer videos and add chapters.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. M adds a marker; press M again to rename it
2. Change a marker to a chapter marker for YouTube chapters
3. Roles colour-code clips: dialogue, music, effects
4. Use the timeline index to find and hide roles



From the FCP User Guide, p. 205

TRY IT

Edit a 3–6 minute video with at least 3 chapter markers.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

How To Create A Chapter Marker In Final Cut Pro

+ Chapter markers → timecodes for YouTube descriptions

PUBLISH TODAY

First long video

KEY SHORTCUTS

M · Opt+M

MANUAL PAGES

p. 205–209, 478

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

WEEK 3 · DAYS 15–21

Creative tools

Masks, keying, tracking, multicam, music sync and thumbnails.

Day 15 Green screen and Magnetic Mask
Day 16 Object tracking
Day 17 Better audio: effects, voiceover, crossfades
Day 18 Multicam and stabilisation
Day 19 Adjustment clips, LUTs and video scopes
Day 20 Edit to the beat and animate
Day 21 Thumbnails and B-roll storytelling

UPLOAD TARGET

A Short every day, plus long videos on Days 18 and 21

END-OF-WEEK CHECK

You can use one creative effect per video without looking it up

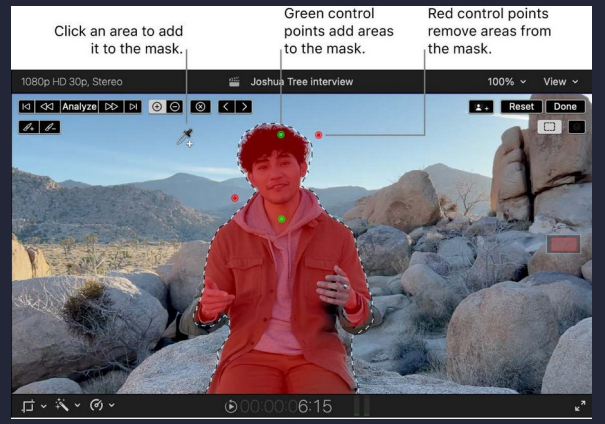
DAY 15

Green screen and Magnetic Mask

Put yourself anywhere, with or without a green screen.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Drag the Keyer effect onto a green-screen clip
2. Place the background clip below as the main storyline
3. Use Magnetic Mask to cut out a person without a green screen
4. Refine the edges with the mask's add and remove points



From the FCP User Guide, p. 646

TRY IT

Put yourself in front of a different background.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

▶️ Final Cut Pro 11 • Complete Guide To The Magnetic Mask
+ FCP Green Screen Tutorial for Beginners (Keyer)

PUBLISH TODAY

Short

KEY SHORTCUTS

Cmd+5 (Effects)

MANUAL PAGES

p. 623–677

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

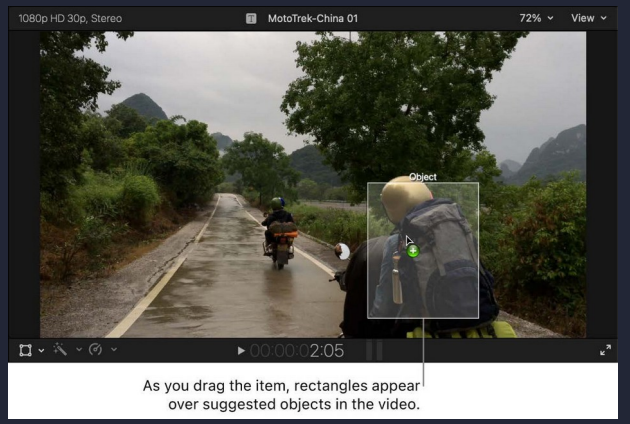
DAY 16

Object tracking

Make text or graphics follow something that moves.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Add a title or image above the moving clip
2. Open the tracker and drag it onto the object in the viewer
3. Click Analyze and let FCP follow the object
4. Fix any drift with tracking keyframes (p. 703)



From the FCP User Guide, p. 697

TRY IT

Attach a name label to a moving person or car.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Object Tracking in FCP – Text Follow a Moving Object
+ Final Cut Pro Text Object Tracking Tutorial

PUBLISH TODAY

Short

KEY SHORTCUTS

—

MANUAL PAGES

p. 693–707

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

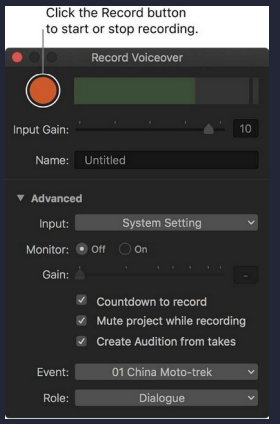
DAY 17

Better audio: effects, voiceover, crossfades

Make your voice clear and confident.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Opt+Cmd+8 opens Record Voiceover; Opt+Shift+A starts recording
2. Add EQ and compression from the Audio effects
3. Opt+T adds a crossfade at the selected audio edit
4. Shift+Cmd+M matches audio between clips



From the FCP User Guide, p. 232

TRY IT

Record a voiceover over B-roll, then clean it up.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

How to Record Your Voice-over In Final Cut Pro
+ How I Process Voice Audio for YouTube

PUBLISH TODAY

Short

KEY SHORTCUTS

Opt+Cmd+8 · Opt+T · Shift+Cmd+M

MANUAL PAGES

p. 232, 248, 261–275

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

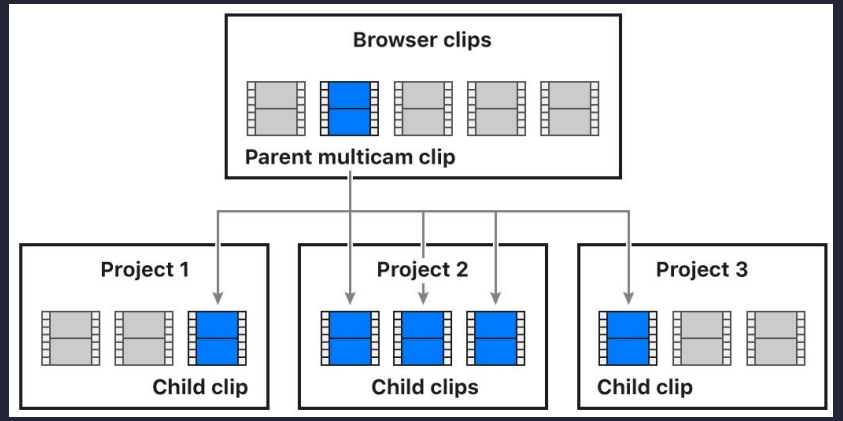
DAY 18

Multicam and stabilisation

Edit two cameras as easily as one.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Select the angles > New Multicam Clip; FCP syncs them by audio
2. Open the angle viewer and switch angles while it plays
3. Press 1, 2, 3 to cut to that angle
4. Stabilise shaky shots in the Video inspector



From the FCP User Guide, p. 514

TRY IT

Film with your phone and webcam at once, then cut between them.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Multicam Editing Tutorial on Final Cut Pro
+ 3 Ways You Can Stabilize Video in Final Cut Pro

PUBLISH TODAY

Long video

KEY SHORTCUTS

1 · 2 · 3 (angles)

MANUAL PAGES

p. 213–219, 513–541

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

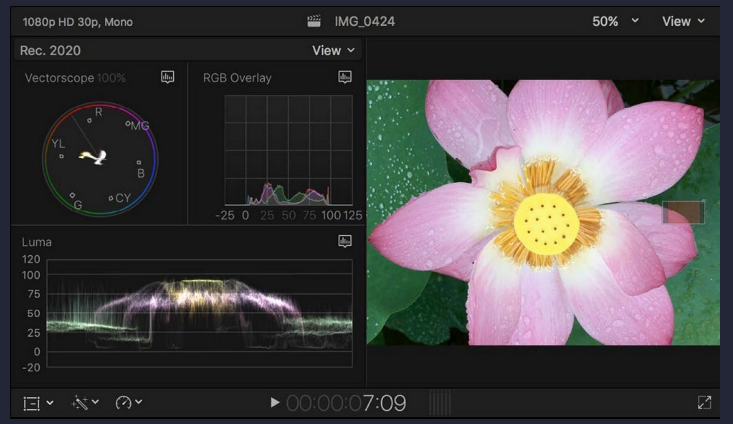
DAY 19

Adjustment clips, LUTs and video scopes

Give your channel a consistent look.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Add an adjustment clip over your whole edit for one look
2. Apply a LUT or Custom LUT effect for a style
3. Cmd+7 shows the video scopes to check exposure
4. Keep skin tones natural (on the vectorscope skin-tone line)



From the FCP User Guide, p. 791

TRY IT

Create one colour look and save it as a preset.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

How to Use Adjustment Layers in Final Cut Pro 11

+ How to correctly use LUTs – 3 methods you must know

PUBLISH TODAY

Short

KEY SHORTCUTS

Cmd+7

MANUAL PAGES

p. 449, 783–800

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today...

DAY 20

Edit to the beat and animate

Sync cuts to music and add movement.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Select the music clip and press Opt+B for Beat Detection
2. Snap cuts to the beat grid with snapping on (N)
3. Add keyframes in the inspector to animate position or scale
4. Use generators for backgrounds and shapes



From the FCP User Guide, p. 468

TRY IT

Cut a 15-second montage exactly on the beat.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Beat Detection Explained (Final Cut Pro 12)
+ How to Use Keyframes to Animate Objects in FCP

PUBLISH TODAY

Music-synced Short

KEY SHORTCUTS

Opt+B · N

MANUAL PAGES

p. 210–214, 451, 467

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

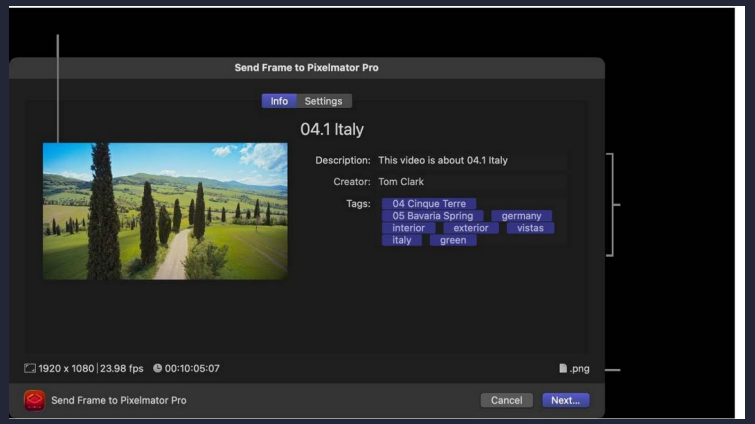
DAY 21

Thumbnails and B-roll storytelling

The thumbnail decides whether people click.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Share > Send Frame to Pixelmator Pro for thumbnails
2. Or add the Save Current Frame destination (p. 894)
3. Big face, 3–4 words, high contrast
4. Cover every jump cut with B-roll that shows what you say



From the FCP User Guide, p. 828

TRY IT

Make 2 thumbnail options and pick the clearer one.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Show-Stopping YouTube Thumbnails with Pixelmator Pro
+ Youtube Thumbnail Creation In Apple Pixelmator Pro

PUBLISH TODAY

Long video

KEY SHORTCUTS

Cmd+E

MANUAL PAGES

p. 828, 894–895

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today...

WEEK 4 · DAYS 22–30

Real-time daily workflow

Batch your work, manage your library, repurpose content and read analytics.

Day 22 Batch day: shoot 5 Shorts at once
Day 23 Edit fast with your template
Day 24 Library management, proxies and backups
Day 25 Turn one long video into three Shorts
Day 26 Faster exports and YouTube SEO
Day 27 Read your analytics and fix your hooks
Day 28 Speed challenge: Short in under 30 minutes
Day 29 Make your best long video
Day 30 Review and plan the next month

UPLOAD TARGET

A Short daily, plus a long video every 2–3 days

END-OF-WEEK CHECK

Shoot, edit and upload a Short in under 30 minutes

DAY 22

Batch day: shoot 5 Shorts at once

Batching is how daily uploads stay sustainable.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Write 5 hooks (the first line of each Short)
2. Set up light and mic once, then film all 5
3. Import into one event; add a keyword for each Short
4. Rate the best take of each with F



Batching is how daily uploads stay sustainable.

TRY IT

Finish the day with 5 Shorts filmed and organised.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

▶ How to Batch Content for YouTube Shorts: Record, Edit, Upload
+ How I Batch Film 4 Videos in 1 Day (Behind the Scenes)

PUBLISH TODAY

Short

KEY SHORTCUTS

Cmd+I · F

MANUAL PAGES

p. 21–38, 89

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

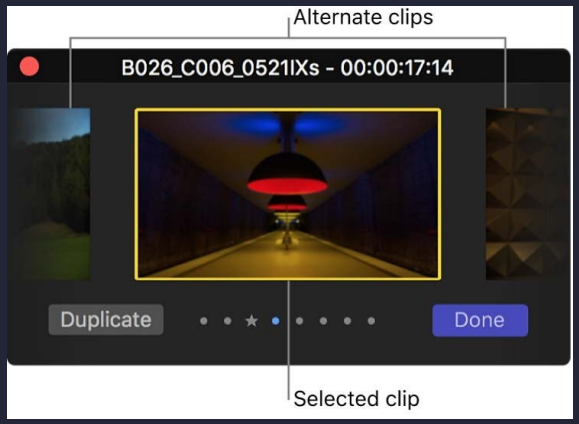
DAY 23

Edit fast with your template

Target: 15 minutes per Short.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Duplicate the template project for each Short
2. Use auditions (Cmd+Y) to compare takes quickly
3. Use the precision editor (Ctrl+E) for perfect cuts
4. Set a timer and stop at 15 minutes



From the FCP User Guide, p. 551

TRY IT

Edit 3 of yesterday's Shorts with a timer running.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Master Auditioning in Final Cut Pro for Perfect Takes
+ How to Use Control-E (Precision Editor) for Perfect Edits

PUBLISH TODAY

Short

KEY SHORTCUTS

Cmd+Y · Ctrl+E

MANUAL PAGES

p. 547–557

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today...

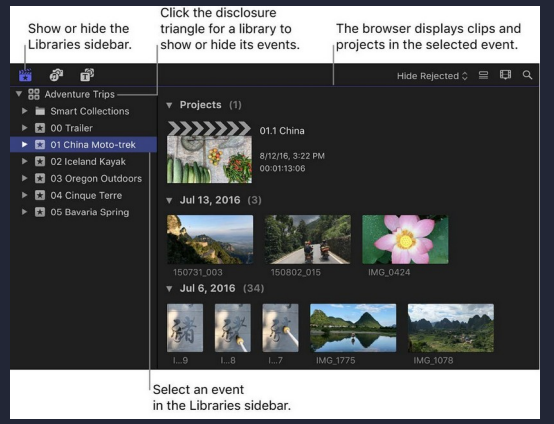
DAY 24

Library management, proxies and backups

Keep FCP fast and your work safe.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Create proxy media for smoother editing of 4K files
2. Delete render files you don't need to free disk space
3. Consolidate media so the library contains everything
4. Back up the library to an external drive weekly



From the FCP User Guide, p. 868

TRY IT

Clean up your library and check your free disk space.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

- Edit faster in Final Cut using proxy media
- \+ How To Delete Render Files in Final Cut Pro (2026)

PUBLISH TODAY

Short

KEY SHORTCUTS

—

MANUAL PAGES

p. 850–876

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

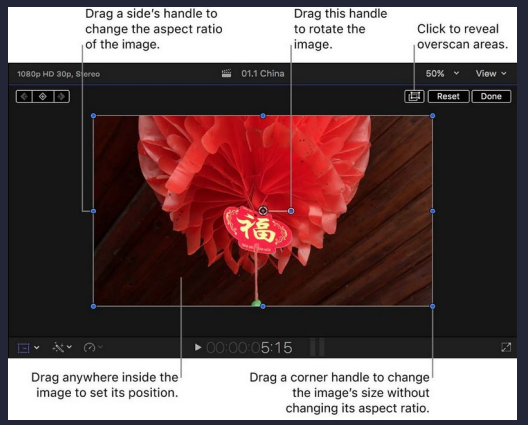
DAY 25

Turn one long video into three Shorts

Get more content from every recording.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Select the long project > Duplicate Project As (p. 123)
2. Choose a vertical format for the copy
3. Use Smart Conform to reframe each clip
4. Cut the 3 best 30–60 second moments



From the FCP User Guide, p. 403

TRY IT

Make 3 Shorts from your Day 14 or Day 21 video.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

▶ Final Cut Pro: Turn Any Video into a Vertical Reel or Short
+ How to Duplicate Your Project in Final Cut Pro

PUBLISH TODAY

Short (repurposed)

KEY SHORTCUTS

Cmd+D

MANUAL PAGES

p. 122–123, 404

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

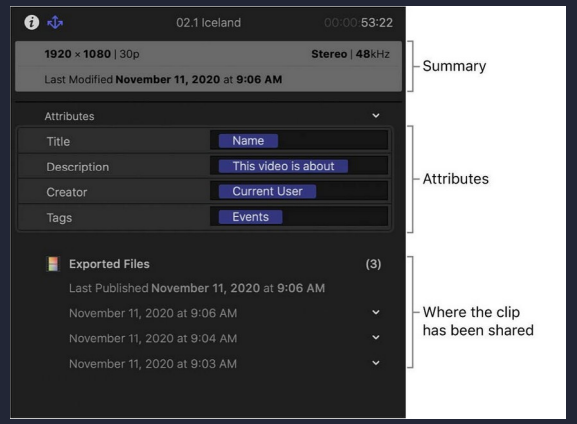
DAY 26

Faster exports and YouTube SEO

Spend less time waiting and more time being found.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Turn on Allow export segmentation for faster H.264 exports
2. Batch-share several Shorts at once (p. 833)
3. Title: keyword first and under 60 characters
4. Schedule uploads in YouTube Studio for a consistent time



From the FCP User Guide, p. 848

TRY IT

Export 3 Shorts in one batch and schedule them for 3 days.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

YouTube SEO Settings 2025

+ How to Rank YouTube Videos – Small & New Channels

PUBLISH TODAY

Short (scheduled)

KEY SHORTCUTS

Cmd+E

MANUAL PAGES

p. 833, 843, 848

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today…

DAY 27

Read your analytics and fix your hooks

Let your audience tell you what works.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. YouTube Studio > Analytics > Content > Shorts
2. Check average view duration and the swipe-away rate
3. Find the second where viewers leave, and cut there next time
4. Rewrite your 3 weakest hooks



Let your audience tell you what works.

TRY IT

Re-edit one Short with a stronger first 2 seconds.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Viewed to Swiped Away Ratio in YouTube Shorts (MUST KNOW)
+ How To Increase Swipe Rate In YouTube Shorts

PUBLISH TODAY

Short

KEY SHORTCUTS

—

MANUAL PAGES

—

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today...

DAY
28

Speed challenge: Short in under 30 minutes

Prove your workflow end to end.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Start a timer before you film
2. Shoot, import, edit, caption and export
3. Upload with title, description and #Shorts
4. Write down which step was slowest



Prove your workflow end to end.

TRY IT

Total time under 30 minutes. Note your time here.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Final Cut Pro Just Made It EASY To Edit YouTube Shorts
+ EDIT FASTER IN FINAL CUT PRO

PUBLISH TODAY

Short

KEY SHORTCUTS

Your fastest shortcuts

MANUAL PAGES

—

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today...

DAY 29

Make your best long video

Use every skill from the month in one video.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Plan: hook, 3 main points, call to action
2. Multicam or B-roll, captions, chapters, colour look
3. Clean audio with a music bed and crossfades
4. Custom thumbnail made in Pixelmator Pro



Use every skill from the month in one video.

TRY IT

Publish the video you're proudest of.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

My Final Cut Pro Video Editing Workflow from Start to Finish
+ How I Edit YouTube Videos (Final Cut Pro Tips & Tricks)

PUBLISH TODAY

Long video

KEY SHORTCUTS

All of them

MANUAL PAGES

Whole guide

MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today...

DAY 30

Review and plan the next month

Look back, then make a plan to keep going.

LEARN: STEP BY STEP

1. Watch your Day 1 and Day 29 videos one after the other
2. Update your template with what you've learned
3. Plan next month's content calendar
4. Decide whether to keep Apple Creator Studio (p. 18)



Look back, then make a plan to keep going.

TRY IT

Write your top 5 lessons from this month in the notes box.

WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Build a YouTube Content Calendar That Actually Works
+ YouTube Creators: Optimize & Evolve Your Content (official)

PUBLISH TODAY

Short

KEY SHORTCUTS

—

MANUAL PAGES

p. 16–18

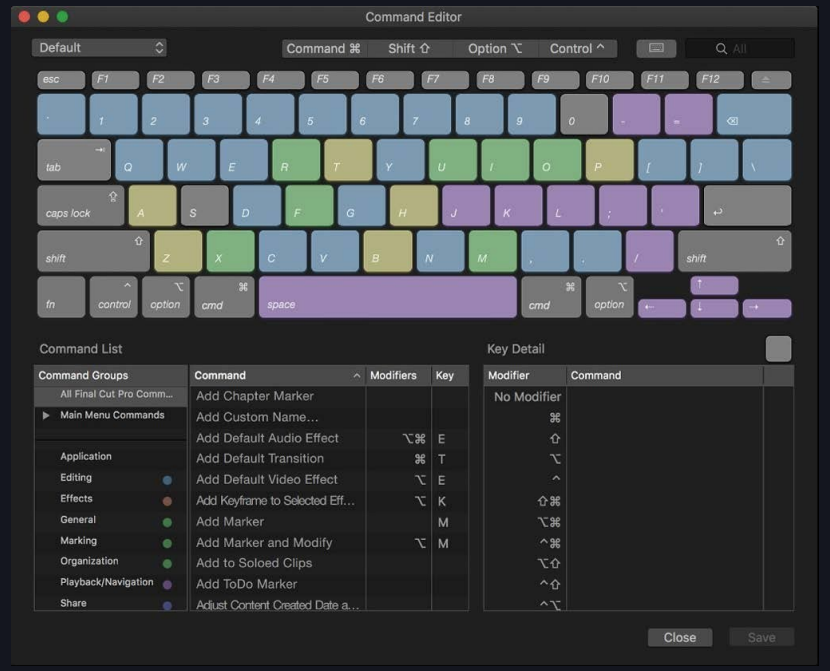
MY NOTES

Click here and type what you learned today...

REFERENCE

Quick reference

Daily workflow · export settings · shortcuts · feature finder · progress tracker. Come back here whenever you forget something.



Your daily 40-minute workflow

1

Shoot

10 min

Phone, vertical, good light, clip-on mic

2

Import

2 min

AirDrop to Mac > FCP > keyword the clips

3

Edit

15 min

Duplicate template, cut, Generate Captions, music

4

Polish

5 min

Enhance Light and Color, Voice Isolation, hook title

5

Export

3 min

Share > Social Platforms, captions burned in

6

Upload

5 min

YouTube Studio: title, #Shorts, schedule



Batch it: film 5 Shorts in one session (Day 22), edit a few at a time, and schedule them. You don’t have to make each one on the day it goes out.

Export settings cheat sheet

Setting	YouTube Short	Long video
Project format	Vertical 1080×1920	1920×1080 (HD) or 3840×2160 (4K)
Frame rate	Same as your footage (usually 30 fps)	Same as your footage
Length	Up to 3 minutes; 15–60 sec works best	Any length (over 15 min needs a verified account)
FCP destination	Share > Social Platforms (p. 894)	Social Platforms, or Export File for a master copy (p. 810)
Captions	Burn in captions (always visible)	Export as a separate caption file, or burn in
Compression	Single-pass (faster)	Multi-pass (better quality)
Speed tip	Allow export segmentation (p. 848)	Allow export segmentation; batch share (p. 833)
In YouTube Studio	Add #Shorts, hook in the title	Chapters from markers, custom thumbnail, end screen

Shortcuts: editing

Keys	What it does
Space	Play or pause
J / K / L	Reverse / stop / forward
I / O	Set range start / end
X	Select the whole clip range
E	Append to the end
W	Insert at playhead
Q	Connect above storyline
D	Overwrite

Keys	What it does
Cmd+B	Cut at playhead
Opt+[/ Opt+]	Trim start / end to playhead
A / B / T	Select / Blade / Trim tool
P / R	Position / Range tool
N	Snapping on or off
V	Enable or disable a clip
Shift+Z	Fit timeline to window
Cmd+Z	Undo

Shortcuts: audio, titles, colour, speed, export

Keys	What it does
Opt+Cmd+A	Enhance Audio
Shift+Cmd+M	Match audio
Ctrl+S	Expand audio
Opt+S	Solo clip
Ctrl+T	Add basic title
Ctrl+Shift+T	Add lower third
Shift+Cmd+S	Generate captions (subtitles)
Cmd+T	Default transition

Keys	What it does
Ctrl+Opt+Cmd+O	Enhance Light and Color
Opt+Cmd+M	Match colour
Cmd+7	Video scopes
Cmd+R	Retime editor
Shift+H / Opt+F	Hold / freeze frame
M	Add marker
Opt+G	New compound clip
Cmd+E	Share to default destination

Feature finder: where is it in the manual?

Topic	Page
Interface and magnetic timeline	9–15
Import media	21–38
Organise (keywords, favourites)	89
New / vertical project	120–127
Add clips (E, W, Q, D)	136–155
Trim and cut	168–187
Markers and chapters	205–209
Edit to the beat	210–214
Stabilise shaky video	216
Audio basics	220–251
Voice Isolation / Enhance Audio	276–278

Topic	Page
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Transitions	389–400
Transform, crop, Ken Burns	401–403
Smart Conform	404
Keyframe animation	467
Roles	478
Compound clips	504
Multicam	513
Retime / speed ramps	558
Green screen keying	623

Topic	Page
Masks / Magnetic Mask	642
Object tracking	693
Colour correction	708
Enhance Light and Color	746
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Video scopes	791
Social Platforms export	894
Thumbnails (Pixelmator Pro)	828
Proxies and media management	850–862
Keyboard shortcuts	897

30-day progress tracker

Type ✓ in a box when you've published that day.

1 ☐	2 ☐	3 ☐	4 ☐	5 ☐	6 ☐	7 ☐	8 ☐	9 ☐	10 ☐
11 ☐	12 ☐	13 ☐	14 ☐	15 ☐	16 ☐	17 ☐	18 ☐	19 ☐	20 ☐
21 ☐	22 ☐	23 ☐	24 ☐	25 ☐	26 ☐	27 ☐	28 ☐	29 ☐	30 ☐

- Week 1: Core editing
- Week 2: Speed and polish
- Week 3: Creative tools
- Week 4: Real-time daily workflow

DAY 31 AND BEYOND

Keep going

- Keep one Short a day, plus one or two long videos a week
- Each month, go deeper into one area: colour, sound or motion graphics
- Reread your My notes boxes every Sunday
- Use the feature finder whenever you forget something

